
IK 520: Foundations of Indian Knowledge Systems in Music

Course Code	IK 520
Course Name	Foundations of Indian Knowledge Systems in Music
L-T-P-C	3-1-0-4
Prerequisites	None
Intended for	B. Tech/MTech/MS/MSc/PhD
Mutual Exclusion	There are no equivalent or overlapping courses across schools.
Approval	64th BoA (May 2026)

Preamble

This course examines Indian music as a structured knowledge system within the framework of Indian Knowledge Systems (IKS). It introduces theoretical foundations, classical treatises and scholarly publications, temple traditions, sources and transmission of music, and interdisciplinary dimensions including musical instruments, acoustics, and cognition. The course is research-oriented and emphasizes analytical learning through assignments and guided projects.

Course Modules

- **Module 1: Introduction to IKS and Concept of Indian Music:** Overview of Indian Knowledge Systems, concepts of Nāda (sound), Śruti and Swara, Bhakti (devotional) tradition, folk traditions, philosophical and cultural foundations of Indian music, evolution of India's musical heritage. (this will be taught along with the practical illustrations) (8 hours)
- **Module 2: Structure of Indian Music:** Swara system and tonal organization, Raga tradition with its structure and framework, Tala as cyclic rhythm and mathematical framework, integration of melody and rhythm through Swara-Sāhitya, foundational principles of Indian musical composition and performance. (12 hours)
- **Module 3: Classical Treatises and Publications:** Introduction to ancient, medieval, and modern musical treatises, inscriptions and paintings as sources of musical history, evolution of musicological thought, research works and publications in Indian music, oral and textual knowledge traditions in the transmission of music. (12 hours)
- **Module 4: Temple Traditions as Knowledge Systems:** Music in ritual and worship, temples as cultural and artistic centres, case studies of Thanjavur, Thiruvavur, Gwalior, and Agra traditions, role of hereditary practitioners and Parampara traditions including Mānganyār tradition, Nāṭya Sangeeth, and Sikh Shabads, relationship between music, sacred spaces, and spiritual experience. The relationship between music, sacred spaces, and spiritual experience is studied alongside the role of royal patronage in sustaining musical traditions in both South and North India. (12 hours)
- **Module 5: Musical Transmission, Instruments, and Interdisciplinary Dimensions:** (12 hours)
 - A. Musical Transmission: Guru-Śiṣya parampara, notation systems, archival traditions, institutional dissemination of music.

- B. Indian Musical Instruments: Classification of instruments into Tata, Avanaddha, Sushira, and Ghana, study of key instruments such as veena, mridangam, tabla, flute, and tanpura, role of instruments in classical and temple traditions.
- C. Interdisciplinary Connections: Music and mathematics through rhythm and permutations, music and physics through acoustics and resonance, music and cognition through perception and memory, music and philosophy through aesthetics and rasa, music and society through cultural continuity, music and wellness beyond performance traditions.

Tutorial Component

The tutorial component includes presentations, short assignments, group projects, discussions, and interactive activities designed to encourage critical engagement with the interdisciplinary dimensions of music and the Indian Knowledge System. These activities aim to help students explore the cultural, philosophical, historical, scientific, and aesthetic aspects of Indian music through collaborative learning and reflective inquiry.

Text Books

1. Sambamurthy. P, *South Indian Music*, Vol: 1-13, Indian Music Publishing House, Madras, 1973
2. Chelladurai P. T, *The Splounder of South Indian Music*, Vaigarai Publishers, 2000.

References

1. Seetha s. *Tañjāvūr as a Seat of Music*. University of Madras, 2001.
2. Gowri Kuppaswamy and Hariharan M. *Music in Indian Royal Kingdoms*. Delhi: B.R. Rhythms, 2015. Print.
3. Day, C. R. *The Music and Musical Instruments of Southern India and the Deccan*. Novello, Ewer & Co., 1891
4. Bhagyalekshmy, S. *Lakshanagranthas in Music*. Thiruvananthapuram: CBH Publications, 1991. ISBN: 8185381135
5. Brahmaśri Subbarāma Dīkṣita. *Saṅgīta Sampradaya Pradarśini (English)*. Vol. 1, The Music Academy, Chennai, Jan 2011.
6. *Music and Temple Ritual in South India: Performing for Śiva* by Isabelle R. Tallotte. Routledge, 2024.
7. Śārṅgadeva. *Saṅgīta Ratnākara*. Edited and translated by R. K. Shringy and Prem Lata Sharma. New Delhi: Munshiram Manoharlal Publishers, various editions.
8. Venkaṭamakhin. *Caturdaṇḍī Prakāśikā*. Edited with English introduction and notes by S. Subrahmanya Sastri. Madras: The Adyar Library and Research Centre, 1934 (reprint editions available).
9. Mataṅga Muni. *Bṛhaddeśī*. Edited by Dr. Prem Lata Sharma. New Delhi: Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts (IGNCA), 1992.